

Look and feel

To start with, let us look at the first thing that a Desktop Environment is supposed to do—make it easy for the user to operate the computer. This is the primary goal of a GUI. If everyone could remember more commands than there are verses in The Mahabharata, then we would not have GUIs at all!

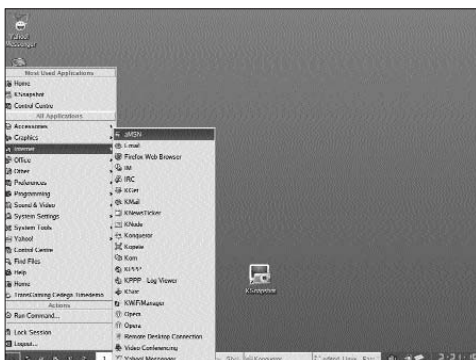
KDE does an excellent job making the Linux newbie feel at home, with its familiar Windows-like feel. GNOME, on the other hand is not so loaded with graphics, but is still easy to use. So here, choosing between the two is just a matter of preference.

The KDE Desktop has a Windows Start Menu imitation at the left bottom of the screen called 'K'. Clicking on it will open up a menu that shows the different software that are installed. For example, there is a menu that says 'Internet', which contains shortcuts to the browser, e-mail client, etc. Then there is a menu called 'Office', which contains the different applications of OpenOffice.org. The time display is to the much-familiar right, where you also find the shortcuts to the four different desktops.

GNOME, however, puts the menu on the top. At the bottom, however, there is a “show desktop” icon—a nice idea! There’s also a shutdown menu right on the GNOME-panel (the equivalent of a taskbar).

Applications

Strictly speaking, an application written for KDE must work on GNOME, and vice versa, provided the libraries that the applications use are also installed. So you are not required to use only those



The K Menu